

500 Registrations in 7 Days on ₹2,000

Workshop: "Build Your First AI Project in 60 Minutes" (free, live) · **Live asset:** <https://ai-workshop-referral-engine.vercel.app/>

Core bet: ₹2,000 can't buy 500 students, so students have to bring each other. Every part of this plan feeds that loop.

1. The student

- **Who:** final-year B.Tech students (2027 batch) in **Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh**, mainly CSE, IT, AI/ML and ECE. I start at my own college, **Amrita Coimbatore**, then nearby colleges (PSG, Kumaraguru, CIT) through people I know. That's a free first ambassador on Day 1.
- **Why they care now:** it's placement season, and interviewers ask "Have you built anything with AI?" Most haven't. AI courses look long, paid or theory-heavy.
- **What makes them register:** a **concrete outcome** (a deployed AI Resume Reviewer, a GitHub link and a resume line, in 60 minutes), **zero risk** (free, one evening, no AI experience needed) and **peer proof** ("37 students from your college registered").

2. The campaign: 3 channels, in order of priority

#	Channel	What I do	Why it works	Regs
1	Campus ambassadors	Recruit 25 club leads and class reps in about 20 colleges. Each gets a tracked link, a WhatsApp message, a poster and a reel.	Class WhatsApp groups beat any ad, and a classmate is a trusted sender.	5,000 reached × 5% ≈ 260
2	Referral loop (my asset)	Every registrant gets an invite link, a 3-person squad and rewards for 1/3/5 friends, plus a college leaderboard.	People share right after they sign up, when their intent is highest, and college pride adds a reason.	~300 × 0.45 ≈ 140
3	Organic social	2 LinkedIn posts and 1 reel showing the finished project, reshared by ambassadors.	Gives ambassadors proof to point to.	≈ 100
Total (target 550 to cover duplicates)				≈ 500

Not doing: paid ads (₹2,000 ≈ 40 sign-ups), cold emails to TPOs (too slow) or a long list of extra channels.

Budget: ₹1,000 top-5 ambassador vouchers (**paid only on results**) · ₹600 lucky draw for students with 3+ referrals · ₹400 boost on Day 5 **only if behind plan**. All other rewards cost nothing.

Daily targets: 40 · 60 · 70 · 80 · 90 · 90 · 70 (= 500). Day 1: seed in my Amrita groups to test the message. Day 3: launch the College Challenge. Day 4: review the numbers and move effort to the best channel. Day 5: social-proof push. Day 7: "closes tonight". **Attendance:** WhatsApp and email reminders 1 day, 1 hour and 10 minutes before. A registration only counts if the student shows up.

3. Experiments: my five hypotheses, all built in

500 sign-ups can't be split five ways (about 50 per version is too few to trust), so each idea is measured the way that suits it.

#	Idea	Hypothesis	What students see	Metric
1	Project Curiosity	Seeing a project they want to build makes students register.	4 project cards and project pages before sign-up. Only the Resume Reviewer is built Sunday; the rest are votes, so nothing is over-promised.	Click rate → sign-up per project
2+5	Squad Challenge (live for all)	Students share more when it's a challenge and a card that represents them.	A 3-person AI squad and a personal share card. Friends fill the inviter's squad.	Share rate, squads completed
3	Campus Identity (A/B)	Campus identity beats a national online workshop.	A: standard page. B: "[College] AI Project Sprint" with the campus count and rank.	Visit → sign-up

#	Idea	Hypothesis	What students see	Metric
4	Instant Reward (A/B)	A useful reward right after sign-up reduces drop-off.	A: confirmation only. B: an AI Project Passport (recommendation, prep checklist, download).	Return rate

The two A/B tests split **different groups** (visitors vs registrants), run on Days 1–3, then everyone gets the winner. The dashboard calls a winner at 95% confidence. I launched squads for everyone because squads only work if friends see the same page. **Guardrail:** show-up rate on the day.

4. What I built: the Referral Engine

- **The student journey:** project pages → a 2-step sign-up → an invite page with a squad, a share card and WhatsApp, Discord and LinkedIn sharing. The site remembers who's registered.
- **Organiser dashboard:** sign-ups vs the daily plan, by channel and college, the viral ratio, all 4 experiment panels and CSV export.
- **Campaign Simulator:** the plan as a live model. It reaches **519 by Day 7**, and only **394 without the referral loop**, which is why the loop is the core bet.
- **Stack:** Vercel serverless and MongoDB Atlas, free to run. Unique indexes block duplicate sign-ups.

Every morning it answers: *Are we on plan, and which channel or college gets our effort today?*

5. Funnel and KPIs: what "on track" means

Stage	Target	How it's measured
Reach (WhatsApp groups, posts)	5,000+ students	Ambassadors × groups × members
Visit the page	~1,500 (30% of reach)	Home-page visitors on the dashboard
Register	500 (≈ 33% of visits)	Live dashboard, against daily targets
Share their invite link	30%+ of registrants	Squad Challenge share rate
Bring a friend	0.45 friends per seeded student	Viral ratio on the dashboard
Show up live	45%+ (≈ 225 builders)	Attendance on the day, after 3 reminders

My north-star number isn't 500 sign-ups. It's ~225 students who actually build and deploy the project, because that's what turns into testimonials, LinkedIn posts and sign-ups for the next workshop.

6. Risks and how I handle them

Risk	What I do
Ambassadors sign up but don't post	Rewards paid only on results , a ready-made content kit, and on Day 4 I replace inactive colleges with the best performers' contacts
Behind plan by Day 5	The ₹400 boost goes to the best-converting post, plus a social-proof message ("300+ students from 18 colleges")
Registrations but low attendance	Reminders 1 day, 1 hour and 10 minutes before, squads (friends attend together) and the Passport prep checklist
Duplicate or fake sign-ups	Phone and email validation; the database rejects repeats
Over-promising	Only the Resume Reviewer is promised for Sunday. Other projects are clearly votes for the next workshop

7. Try it yourself

- **Student view:** home page with project cards → [College Help Chatbot page](#) → [2-step sign-up](#)
- **Campus Identity, version B:** [Amrita AI Project Sprint](#)
- **Plan as a live model:** [Campaign Simulator](#) (press Run, then "No referral loop")
- **Leaderboard:** [College Challenge](#) · **Code:** github.com/navadeep555/ai-workshop-referral-engine